

Checklist

Engineering Executive: Engineering Strategy

Before You Start

- ☐ I'm confident in my **diagnosis** of the organization.
- ☐ I'm **willing** and able to **enforce** this strategy.
- ☐ I believe this strategy will create **real leverage** (not just sound good).
- ☐ I'm ready to **personally write** the strategy (not fully delegate it).

Define the Strategy Structure

Make sure the document clearly includes:

- ☐ **Diagnosis** — What is actually going on?
- ☐ **Guiding Policies** — What principles will govern decisions?
- ☐ **Coherent Actions** — What concrete actions implement the policies?

Diagnosis Checklist

- ☐ I've reviewed the **roadmap, financial plan**, and business **priorities**.
- ☐ I've incorporated **survey data** (developer productivity, culture, etc.).
- ☐ I've identified **root causes** (not just symptoms).
- ☐ I **validated** my diagnosis with:
 - ☐ Senior engineering managers
 - ☐ Staff+ engineers

- ☐ Product leadership
- ☐ Executive peers
- ☐ I actively sought out **skeptics**.
- ☐ I **avoided copying assumptions** from previous roles.
- ☐ The diagnosis clearly explains the **real constraints**.

Guiding Policies Checklist

A. Resource Allocation

- ☐ Our engineering resource allocation is explicitly defined.
- ☐ The allocation clearly maps back to the diagnosis.
- ☐ We are investing in unowned but critical areas (e.g., security, reliability, developer productivity).

B. Fundamental Rules

- ☐ There are clear organization-wide standards (tech stack, lifecycle, review process, etc.).
- ☐ Exceptions have a defined approval path.
- ☐ Each rule includes an explanation of why it matters.

C. Decision-Making Model

- ☐ It's clear what teams can decide independently.
- ☐ It's clear what requires review or approval.
- ☐ There is a defined escalation path.
- ☐ We've explained *why* decisions are structured this way.

Guiding Policies Quality Check

Each policy is:

- ☐ **Applicable** — Useful in real trade-offs.
- ☐ **Enforced** — There is accountability.

- ☐ **Leverage-Creating** — Produces compounding impact.

If any policy fails one of these → reconsider it.

Coherent Actions Checklist

Enforcement

- ☐ There's a process to maintain policies.
- ☐ There's an ongoing process for evaluating exceptions.
- ☐ Enforcement ownership is clear.

Escalations

- ☐ There's a small, clear escalation path.
- ☐ Teams know how to challenge a policy constructively.

Transitions

- ☐ We've defined how we move from current → future state.
- ☐ Resource shifts are explicit.
- ☐ Migration plans (if any) are clear.
- ☐ Organizational changes are defined if needed.

Writing Process Checklist

Working Group

- ☐ I identified 3–5 trusted stakeholders for early feedback.
- ☐ I iterated the diagnosis 1:1 with them.
- ☐ I refined guiding policies with them.
- ☐ I considered (private) feedback from 2–3 external engineering executives.

Broader Stakeholders

- ☐ I shared the diagnosis + guiding policies with key stakeholders.

- ☐ I socialized before announcing.
- ☐ I removed sensitive content before wider circulation.

Pre-Launch

- ☐ I met 1:1 with likely strong dissenters.
- ☐ I incorporated valid feedback (without weakening core intent).

Launch Checklist

- ☐ Scheduled strategy presentation meeting.
- ☐ Explained the rationale behind decisions.
- ☐ Set short feedback window ($\approx$ 1 week).
- ☐ Finalized document.
- ☐ Sent formal announcement.
- ☐ Committed to reviewing impact in $\sim$ 2 months.
- ☐ Set expectation for annual refresh cadence.

Missing Company Strategy Check

If broader company strategies are undocumented:

- ☐ I clarified business strategy (even informally).
- ☐ I clarified the product strategy.
- ☐ I clarified the investment thesis across functions.
- ☐ I understand cash-flow constraints.
- ☐ I understand competitive threats.
- ☐ I understand the distribution model.
- ☐ I understand how success is measured.

Ongoing Review

- ☐ **Policies** are being **followed**.
- ☐ **Exceptions** are handled consistently.
- ☐ The **escalation** process is working.
- ☐ Resource **allocation** reflects stated priorities.
- ☐ The strategy is creating **visible leverage**.
- ☐ We **review impact** at defined intervals.